

KING OF EGYPT Born c.1302 BCE Died c.1213 BCE

Rameses II

“All the lands... have fallen prostrate **beneath his sandals** for eternity.”

PEACE AGREEMENT WITH THE HITTITES, c.1258 BCE

The greatest pharaoh of the New Kingdom era (c. 1550–1069 BCE), Rameses II reigned supreme for almost 70 years and brought a stability and prosperity to Egypt. Like a present-day international statesman, he skillfully used diplomacy, military strategy, and propaganda to promote Egypt and, maintain his empire. In doing so he became a major figure in Middle Eastern politics.

The future Rameses II was born just before the 19th dynasty (c. 1295–1187 BCE), and became its third pharaoh. From his father,

Seti I, Rameses inherited an established empire that stretched from modern-day Syria in the north to Sudan (then Nubia) in the south. Like his father, he had territorial ambitions in Syria, but he had to contend with the threat from the Hittite Empire (see pp.78–79) further north in Anatolia.

His most famous confrontation with the Hittites was at the battle of Kadesh (or Qadesh) in Syria in c.1275 BCE. Rameses claimed this as a single-handed victory for himself, while others said the Hittites won decisively. The truth is probably somewhere in between, with neither side winning outright or making any major gains.



Portrait and cartouche

This impressive statue of Rameses II (left) stood in the temple of Luxor, in Egypt. The oval carving, or cartouche, (right) has symbols representing Rameses as king, and wearing the double crown of Upper and Lower Egypt.

Rameses the diplomat

Around 1258 BCE, after further skirmishes, the

Hittites and Egyptians drew up a groundbreaking agreement, effectively ending hostilities between them (see right). Mindful of his role as a diplomat serving Egypt's wider interests, Rameses later underlined this new accord by making at least one Hittite princess one of his wives.

The new, friendly tone of relations between the two powers is also clear from the letters found in the archives of the Hittite capital, Hattusha. Like the famous “Amarna Letters” from the reigns of Amenophis III and Akhenaten (see pp.64–65), this correspondence is written on clay tablets in Akkadian cuneiform script (the language of



Rameses II as a boy

This limestone fragment from a stele (commemorative pillar) shows Rameses sitting next to hieroglyphs that indicate he is destined to become king of Egypt. He wears the side braid and a heavy ear decoration that were typical of a young Egyptian prince.